

Taika Waititi's Screenplay Craft: Actionable Technique Patterns for 2D Animated Comedy Shorts

Executive Summary

This report reverse-engineers Taika Waititi's screenplay techniques into transferable, mechanical patterns for writing 3–5 minute 2D animated comedy shorts with emotional depth. It draws on Waititi's own descriptions of his process, close analysis of his screenplays (particularly *Jojo Rabbit*, *What We Do in the Shadows*, *Hunt for the Wilderpeople*, *Boy*, and his short films *Two Cars*, *One Night* and *Tama Tū*), and structural breakdowns of specific scenes. Each section isolates the construction principle behind the effect.

1. Dialogue Mechanics

The "Scripted Improv" Construction Technique

Waititi's dialogue sounds improvised because he builds in the rhythmic properties of natural speech — false starts, mid-thought redirections, and asymmetric exchanges — but every beat serves a dramatic function. His method has three layers:

Layer 1: Write loose, then strip to bone. Waititi writes one or two drafts at 110–120 pages, reads the script once, then deletes it from his computer and rewrites entirely from memory. The result is a 70-page skeleton — "the bare bones of the story and the most resonant bits... not funny, no real heart, but it's the structure." He then adds humor and texture back in. This process means every line in the final script has survived a memory filter: if you couldn't remember it, it wasn't essential. The dialogue that remains has been unconsciously pressure-tested for resonance.[1]

Layer 2: Write dialogue by hand first. Waititi writes all dialogue longhand before typing, which he describes as a method to avoid getting stuck on blank pages. Handwriting forces a conversational cadence — you can't type faster than you think, so lines naturally adopt the rhythm of someone actually speaking. This is why his dialogue has breath marks, mid-sentence subject changes, and incomplete thoughts. These aren't afterthoughts; they're baked in during initial composition.[2]

Layer 3: Build the scene goal, leave the path open. On *What We Do in the Shadows*, Waititi and Clement scripted the full film structure and knew "how every scene would start and end," but the dialogue was almost entirely improvised. They would tell actors: "Here's the goal — from the beginning of the scene to the end, you have to get this achieved. Here's your mission: convince this person to do this". This technique creates dialogue that wanders naturally toward its target rather than driving straight at it — producing that mid-thought, slightly lost quality.[3][4]

Deadpan Setup: What's On the Page

Waititi's deadpan is constructed through a specific page-level technique: **the script creates the absurd situation; the script directs the character to play it straight; the comedy lives in the gap.** He rarely uses parentheticals to indicate "deadpan" — instead, the action lines describe matter-of-fact behavior in an absurd context.

In the *Jojo Rabbit* screenplay, when Jojo and imaginary Hitler discuss strategy, the action lines are written in a flat, operational tone — "Jojo and Hitler again strategize in his room" — while the dialogue itself treats an insane premise (a child consulting imaginary Hitler about a Jewish girl in his attic) as a mundane tactical conversation. The deadpan isn't in a parenthetical "(deadpan)" — it's structural. The script treats the absurd as normal, and that flatness IS the comedy.[5]

His direction to actors reinforces this: "I'll give them a line reading. I'll say, 'Just say it exactly like this.' Sometimes I'll just say, 'Count to three and then say that'". The script builds deadpan by writing dialogue that a character would say in complete earnest — the humor emerges because the audience recognizes the absurdity the character doesn't.

[1]

Interruption and Trail-Off Patterns

Waititi's dialogue interruptions follow a structural pattern: **characters interrupt when they've stopped listening, not when they disagree.** This is distinct from Aaron Sorkin-style interruptions (which signal intellectual engagement) or Tarantino-style overlaps (which signal power dynamics). In Waititi's scripts, characters interrupt because they're inside their own heads.

From the *Jojo Rabbit* script, when Jojo tries to explain himself to Elsa, she doesn't wait for him to finish because she's already categorized him — she trails off into her own thought, picks up a different thread, or physically does something that signals she's moved past what he's saying. The pattern: **Character A makes a statement → Character B responds to an earlier part of that statement or to something entirely internal → Character A adjusts course mid-sentence.** This creates the sensation of two people each having slightly different conversations simultaneously.[6]

Humor Placement: What vs. How vs. Contrast

Waititi rotates between three distinct humor mechanisms, and the rotation itself is the technique:

Film	Scene	Hum or Locat ion	Mechanism
<i>What We Do in the Shadows</i>	Flat meeting about dishes	WHAT they say	Vampires using mundane household complaint language about centuries-old grievances[7]
<i>Jojo Rabbit</i>	Secretary: "What was it, a lipstick bomb?"	HOW it's said	A throwaway observation that's cruel and funny, delivered as a genuine question with no malice[5]
<i>Hunt for the Wilderpeople</i>	Bella's funeral scene	CONTRAST	The priest's rambling, incoherent eulogy delivered in complete earnest while two devastated characters sit in silence[8]
<i>Boy</i>	"Can you stop calling me 'dad'? It sounds weird... How about 'Shogun'?"	WHAT + CONTRAST	The line is funny on its face AND funny because a father is saying it to his son[9]
<i>Jojo Rabbit</i>	Yorki's paper uniform "impervious to damage"	WHAT + CONTRAST	The line is inherently absurd, but the contrast with actual war makes it devastating[6]

The structural principle: **in any given scene, Waititi picks ONE primary humor channel and commits to it.** He doesn't stack mechanisms within a single joke — the dish-meeting scene in *Shadows* is entirely WHAT-driven; the funeral in *Wilderpeople* is

entirely CONTRAST-driven. This clarity is what makes each joke land cleanly.

Character Voice Differentiation

In ensemble casts, Waititi differentiates characters through their **relationship to self-awareness**, not through verbal tics or catchphrases:

- **Viago** (*Shadows*): Knows he's embarrassing, tries to manage it — humor from the gap between his self-awareness and his incompetence[4]
- **Vladislav** (*Shadows*): Believes he's still impressive, despite centuries of evidence otherwise — humor from delusion that the character half-recognizes[4]
- **Deacon** (*Shadows*): Genuinely doesn't understand why things aren't working — humor from pure obliviousness[7]
- **Yorki** (*Jojo Rabbit*): Sees the world clearly but has zero alarm about it — humor from calm observation of horror[6]
- **Klenzendorf** (*Jojo Rabbit*): Knows exactly what's happening and has given up caring — humor from exhausted capitulation[6]

The technique: **assign each character a position on the awareness spectrum, then write every line from that position.** A character who is oblivious will produce different humor from the same situation than a character who is self-aware but impotent.

2. Scene Construction

The Comedy-Drama Seam: Simultaneous, Not Alternating

Waititi's signature move is scenes that are funny AND emotionally resonant in the same moment. The mechanical structure has three components:

Component 1: Ground the comedy in a real emotional need. In *Jojo Rabbit*, Jojo writes fake letters from Nathan to Elsa. The scene is funny — a ten-year-old boy writing a breakup letter in a man's voice, then immediately writing a reconciliation letter. But the underlying

action is a child trying to manipulate a girl he's developing feelings for, and Elsa knows exactly what he's doing. She cries at the first letter and is "a little amused" by the second. The comedy and the emotion aren't alternating — they're the same gesture viewed from two angles.[6]

Component 2: Let the character's emotional truth BE the joke.

Waititi told The Creative Independent: "I like when something tragic is happening and then it's undercut with a laugh, or something's funny and then the carpet's pulled out and it just nose dives into a tragedy. I like a bit of see-saw going on". But the most effective version isn't the see-saw — it's when both exist simultaneously. The Bella funeral scene in *Wilderpeople* works because the priest's incompetence isn't a comedic digression from grief — it IS the grief. The scene shows what happens when death arrives and the ritual meant to honor it is inadequate. The laughter and the sadness have the same source.[8]

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Component 3: Never let the audience decide which register they're in. Waititi specifically shot a "normal sad funeral" for the *Wilderpeople* scene and rejected it because "it had no real impact". The principle: **if the audience can categorize a scene as "the sad part," they armor up. If they're laughing when the devastation arrives, the armor is down.**[1]

Scene Openings

Waititi's scenes typically open with a character already mid-action or mid-conversation. The *Jojo Rabbit* script rarely has establishing beats — characters enter scenes already engaged. The Elsa confrontation scenes begin with Jojo already in the room, not entering it. *Hunt for the Wilderpeople* uses chapter title cards as scene openers, which function as cold-open resets — each title card gives the audience permission to laugh at the absurdity of the title before the emotional content of the chapter arrives.[10][5]

Scripting Awkward Silence

Waititi scripts pauses through action lines rather than the word "beat." In the *Jojo Rabbit* script, the silence after Elsa reads Jojo's fake letter isn't written as "(beat)" — it's written as physical description: Elsa's reaction, then Jojo's observation of that reaction. The technique: **replace "beat" with a micro-action — a character looking away, adjusting something, breathing.** This gives the pause a visual life that translates directly to animation, where a "beat" is meaningless but a character slowly lowering their eyes is a drawable moment.[6]

Physical Comedy in Action Lines

Waititi writes physical comedy with the precision of choreography notation. The grenade scene in *Jojo Rabbit* is scripted as: "He hurls the grenade like a war hero. It flies through the air, bounces off a tree, hits another one, deflects off a nearby branch and ricochets backwards, landing only 6-feet away from Jojo". Note the construction: each impact is a separate clause, building rhythm. The humor is in the accumulation — the grenade's journey gets worse with each conjunction. The structural pattern for writing visual gags in action lines: **each beat of the physical joke gets its own clause, creating a rhythm the reader can "see."**[5]

Scene Length and Rhythm

Waititi's scenes are short by drama standards, long by comedy standards. A video essay analysis of his work notes that "the whole movie has an eccentric rhythm because this director is confident enough to let scenes sit and breathe before accelerating his narrative with peppy deadpan montages". In *Hunt for the Wilderpeople*, the Leonard Cohen tracking-shot montage compresses what could be ten scenes into a single continuous movement — time and space merge. The pattern: **short scenes when things are happening TO characters; longer, breathing scenes when characters are happening to each other.** Action and plot compress; relationship and observation expand.[11]

3. Structural Patterns

Emotional Arcs Within Comedy Frameworks

Waititi builds devastating emotional moments using a specific structural technique: **he earns the audience's trust through comedy, then uses that trust as a delivery system for emotion.** A video essay explains the principle: "If a character makes us laugh then usually we like the character, which means we care about what happens to them, which means the dramatic story elements then have more weight".[12]

In *Boy*, the structure is: Boy's fantasy version of his father (funny) → gradual revelation that the father is a pathetic criminal (still funny, but with growing unease) → the birthday scene where the fantasy fully collapses (devastating). The audience has been laughing at Boy's inventions about his dad — "master carver, deep sea treasure diver, captain of the rugby team" — and each laugh is an investment in Boy's emotional world. When that world collapses, the audience isn't just watching a character be sad; they're losing something they participated in building.[9]

In *Jojo Rabbit*, the same principle operates at a larger scale. The entire first half trains the audience to laugh at Nazi imagery by making it absurd. Every Hitler joke, every ridiculous Hitler Youth exercise, every bumbling officer is teaching the audience that this world is safe to laugh at. That training is the setup. Rosie's hanging is the punchline.[12][6]

The "Turn" — Executing the Shift Mid-Laugh

The structural signature of Waititi's emotional turns is: **the devastating moment arrives during or immediately after a comic scene, with zero tonal preparation.** The principle is that **the comedy IS the preparation — it lowers the audience's emotional defenses.**

In *Jojo Rabbit*: Jojo has just had a comic encounter with Yorki (pages 74–76), who is wearing a paper uniform and claims it's "impervious to damage." This is pure comedy. Then, within a few pages (pages 89–90), Jojo follows a butterfly to the gallows and discovers his mother's

body. There is no transitional scene. No ominous music cue written into the script. No darkening tone. The butterfly — a symbol of lightness — literally leads him to death.[6]

In *Hunt for the Wilderpeople*: Bella's death occurs abruptly, off-screen, between scenes. The very next scene is the absurd funeral where Waititi himself plays an incompetent priest. The comedy doesn't follow the grief as "comic relief" — it arrives simultaneously with the grief, producing a scene where laughter and tears occupy the same physical space.[8]

The setup-to-turn ratio in Waititi's features is approximately 75/25: roughly three-quarters of the runtime is spent building the comic world and the audience's investment in it, with the major emotional turn arriving in the final quarter. In *Boy*, the reveal of Alamein's true character arrives in the third act. In *Jojo Rabbit*, Rosie's death arrives at approximately the 75% mark.[13][6]

Pacing Signatures

Waititi accelerates during external action and decelerates during interpersonal exchange. His pacing triggers follow a pattern:

- **Accelerate when:** society intrudes on personal relationships (the Gestapo visit in *Jojo Rabbit*, the manhunt escalation in *Wilderpeople*), physical comedy unfolds (the grenade sequence), or montage compresses time[11]
- **Decelerate when:** two characters are negotiating emotional territory (Jojo/Elsa conversations, Ricky/Hec in the bush), a character confronts reality (Boy seeing his father clearly for the first time), or silence says more than dialogue[14]

Hunt for the Wilderpeople uses chapter titles as pacing gear-shifts — each new chapter resets the audience's rhythmic expectations.[10]

Ensemble Management

Waititi manages ensembles by giving each character a **narrative function that doubles as a comedy function**. In *Jojo Rabbit*, Yorki is the comic relief character AND the reality check character — he's the one who tells Jojo the Jews "seemed normal" and later delivers the

news that Hitler killed himself. Klenzendorf is the bureaucratic obstacle AND the secret protector — his scenes serve plot mechanics while simultaneously being funny. The structural approach: **every ensemble character must justify their existence on both the comedy axis and the plot axis simultaneously**. Characters who are only funny get cut; characters who only serve the plot don't get written.[6]

4. Animation / Visual Storytelling Relevance

Techniques That Transfer Directly to 2D Animation

Several of Waititi's live-action techniques are not just transferable to 2D animation — they're arguably more powerful in that medium:

Reaction shots as comedy infrastructure. Waititi's comedy frequently depends on a character's non-reaction to an absurd event. In *What We Do in the Shadows*, the documentary format means the camera catches characters' faces during other characters' absurd monologues. In 2D animation, you control the reaction shot absolutely — you can hold a character's expression for exactly as many frames as the joke needs. The animation equivalent: **design "reaction holds" — specific expressions that get held for 8–12 frames longer than feels natural, creating comedic tension through stillness**.[7]

Accumulating physical comedy. The grenade scene's clause-by-clause construction ("bounces off a tree, hits another one, deflects off a nearby branch...") translates directly to animation timing where each impact can be given distinct staging. In animation, you can push this further — objects can defy physics in ways that amplify the accumulation.[5]

The deadpan character in an absurd world. Waititi's "straight face in absurd situation" is the foundational principle of classic animation comedy (Buster Keaton's heirs include every character from Daria to early Squidward). For expression sheets: **design a "neutral resting face" that is the character's most-used expression. The comedy comes from how rarely they deviate from it, and how small those deviations are.**

Visual Tone / Emotional Content Contrast

Jojo Rabbit uses deliberately bright, saturated colors during its depiction of Nazi Germany. The visual design choice is scripted: the world is seen through Jojo's eyes, and to a ten-year-old believer, this world is exciting and beautiful. The color palette is the subjective lens of a child's perception.[15][12]

For animated shorts, this translates to: **design the visual world to match the protagonist's emotional state, not the scene's objective reality.** If your character is oblivious to danger, the color palette should be warm and inviting even as the situation deteriorates. The audience will feel the dissonance — the gap between what they see and what they know — and that dissonance produces both comedy and dread simultaneously.

Waititi's approach to framing Rosie's shoes — repeated low-angle shots of her feet throughout the film, so that when Jojo discovers her hanging body, the audience recognizes her shoes before understanding the scene — is a technique built for animation. **Visual motifs can be planted more precisely in animation because every frame is intentional.** Design a recurring visual element (a hat, a gesture, a color) that accumulates meaning through repetition, then weaponize it in the emotional climax.[16][15]

Deadpan Expression Sheets

For translating Waititi's deadpan to character design: the key is **asymmetry of expression investment.** In his films, the funniest characters move the least facial muscles. Design your deadpan character with:

- A default expression that reads as "mildly processing" — not blank, not engaged, somewhere between
- Maximum three subtle expression variations (slight eyebrow raise, slight mouth downturn, slight eye-widening) that signal internal reaction without breaking the deadpan surface
- Reserve full expression changes for the emotional turn — when the deadpan character finally reacts fully, the audience feels it as a seismic event precisely because the character has been expressively restrained for the entire runtime

5. Transferable Techniques for Short-Form

Two Cars, One Night (11 minutes): Compression Mechanics

Waititi's Oscar-nominated short demonstrates how his feature techniques compress. The film places three children in a pub carpark at night and lets a relationship develop through cross-car dialogue. What survives from his feature technique:[17][18]

- **A single contained location** — the carpark functions like a stage. Compression requires spatial constraint.
- **Dialogue-driven character revelation** — the children reveal their worlds through how they talk, not through plot events. Romeo insults Polly, then pivots to curiosity. The pattern: aggression → interest → vulnerability unfolds in under twelve minutes.[19]
- **Comedy from childhood mimicry of adult behavior** — the children flirt the way they've seen adults flirt, badly. This is the same innocence-as-lens technique Waititi uses in features.[12]

What doesn't survive: extended montage, subplot, ensemble management, and the slow accumulation of motifs (the shoes in *Jojo Rabbit* require 60+ minutes to build meaning).

Tama Tū: Comedy Under Pressure

Tama Tū places Māori Battalion soldiers in a ruined building, hiding from enemy forces. They joke, tease, and laugh — until a crow flies in, symbolizing death, and they go silent. The short's technique: **comedy as coping mechanism, interrupted by reality**. The humor doesn't alternate with the danger; it coexists with it. The soldiers' jokes ARE the tension, because the audience knows that any sound could kill them.[20]

For 3–5 minute animated shorts: this is the most directly transferable structure. **Place characters in a situation where humor is their only tool for managing fear or discomfort, then let reality intrude**. The comedy and the emotional weight share the same engine.

Comedy-Drama Balance in 3–5 Minutes

In features, Waititi can spend 75% of runtime in comedy mode before executing the emotional turn. In shorts, the ratio must invert: **you need to establish the emotional stakes within the first 30 seconds, then let comedy operate in service of those stakes throughout.**

The reason: audiences need a reason to care before they'll accept the tonal shift, and in 3 minutes, you can't earn that caring through comedy alone — you must signal it immediately.

The effective short-form ratio is approximately: **15% emotional grounding → 60% comedy that reveals character → 25% emotional payoff that recontextualizes the comedy.** Compare this to Waititi's feature ratio of 75% comedy / 25% emotional payoff.[6]

Mockumentary/Confessional in Short Animated Format

Waititi's mockumentary technique — the talking-head confessional intercut with "documentary footage" — compresses well into animated shorts for a specific structural reason: **the confessional creates instant interiority.** A character looking at camera and speaking directly tells you who they think they are; the "documentary" footage shows who they actually are. The gap is the comedy.[21][7]

In the *What We Do in the Shadows* TV series, each episode does scripted takes first, then "funsies" (improvised takes), giving the show its naturalistic texture. For animated shorts using this structure, you don't need true improv — you need the appearance of mid-thought speech patterns: sentence fragments, self-corrections, and glances at camera that feel spontaneous. Write these by hand first, as Waititi does, to capture conversational rhythm.[22][2]

The confessional format works particularly well for shorts because it eliminates exposition scenes — a character can tell you their situation directly, freeing screen time for comic situation and emotional payoff.

Scripted "Improv" Density in 3 Minutes

In features, Waititi's naturalistic dialogue includes many lines that serve character texture but not plot function — the wandering, the false starts, the non-sequiturs. In a 3-minute short, you can afford approximately **two to three "texture" lines** — lines that exist purely to make dialogue feel real. More than that, and the short feels aimless. The technique: **write the scene with full naturalistic dialogue (5+ minutes), then cut to the bone, preserving only texture lines that also serve character revelation.** This mirrors Waititi's own delete-and-rewrite process, applied at scene scale.[1]

6. Process

Writing Method

Waititi's writing process has a distinctive sequence:[23][1]

1. **Conceive the opening and closing images first** — "This will be a cool way to open a film... this will be a cool way to end it"[23]
2. **Write scattered scenes and sequences** — "I'll put in some scenes throughout. I think this would be a great scene." He does not write linearly[23]
3. **Glue sequences together** — "When I've got enough of these scenes or sequences, then lazily just glue them all together with some sort of connecting scenes"[23]
4. **Write 1–2 full drafts** (110–120 pages)
5. **Read once, then delete** — Puts the file on an external drive and rewrites from memory, producing a ~70-page structural skeleton[1]
6. **Add humor, heart, and texture back in** — Writes "the longest version of the scene knowing that I can cut it down"[1]
7. **Write all dialogue by hand** before typing[2]

What's On the Page vs. Discovered on Set

The ratio varies dramatically by project:

- **Boy:** Primarily scripted, with Waititi performing as Alamein based on his own father[4]

- ***What We Do in the Shadows (film)***: Structure fully scripted, dialogue almost entirely improvised. 125 hours of footage cut to 86 minutes[24][4]
- ***Jojo Rabbit***: Fully scripted screenplay (adapted from a novel), with the naturalistic quality built into the writing itself[5]
- ***Thor: Ragnarok***: Waititi claimed 80% of dialogue was improvised[25]

The on-set technique across all projects: Waititi gives actors a clear scene goal, allows exploration within that goal, and edits to find the take with the best timing. He frequently gives line readings — "Say it exactly like this" — and uses physical constraints to alter performance: "This entire scene, you're not allowed to move your hands".[3][1]

Comedy Training Roots

Waititi was a member of the five-man comedy troupe *So You're a Man* at Victoria University of Wellington in the mid-1990s, alongside Jemaine Clement and Bret McKenzie. He and Clement formed the comedy duo *The Humourbeasts*, which won New Zealand's highest comedy accolade, the Billy T Award, in 1999. Their act included vampire characters as early as 2000, which eventually became *What We Do in the Shadows*. [26][27]

This background manifests in his screenplay structure in three ways: **(1) Scene-as-bit construction** — many Waititi scenes have the architecture of a comedy sketch (premise, escalation, button), **(2) Comfort with audience discomfort** — improv and stand-up train you to hold a silence, to let awkwardness do the work, **(3) Character-first comedy** — improv trains you to build humor from character behavior rather than from joke construction. Waititi has said he doesn't know any comedy "rules" — "I just know what I think is funny. It usually comes from the taste I've developed over the years". [1]

Cultural Specificity as Universality

Waititi achieves universality through specificity, not despite it. His approach: tell "normal stories about general human conditions, but tell them in a very unique place from indigenous authentic people who know the specific culture". In *Boy*, the Māori community setting, the Michael Jackson obsession, the specific slang — none of this is explained or translated. Yet the film became New Zealand's highest-grossing film because the emotional core (a child's fantasy about an absent parent collapsing upon contact with reality) is universally recognizable.[28][13][2]

The technique is not "add cultural detail for flavor" — it's **"make the cultural specificity structurally necessary."** In *Boy*, Boy's fantasy about his father isn't just any fantasy — it's inflected by Māori masculine ideals and by the specific pop culture of 1984 New Zealand. In *Hunt for the Wilderpeople*, Ricky Baker's dialogue and worldview are shaped by growing up Māori in the foster system. The specificity doesn't decorate the story; it generates the story.[29][9]

Waititi told CBC Radio: "I like it when our experience is presented in a way that feels normal... putting Indigenous actors in spaces that other people are in, and not boxing them into telling stories specific to their culture or their trauma". The principle for any writer: **don't exoticize your characters' cultural context — make it the water they swim in, unremarked upon, and the audience will recognize the human behavior even if they don't recognize the cultural container.**[29]

Application Framework: From Waititi Technique to Animated Short

For a 3–5 minute animated comedy short with emotional depth, distill Waititi's techniques into this construction sequence:

1. **Start with the emotional endpoint.** What truth does the character confront? Build backward from that moment.
2. **Design the comedy as a delivery system for that truth.** Every joke should be a brick in the wall that the emotional moment will break.

3. **Ground comedy in a single contained situation** (carpark, hiding place, waiting room) — spatial constraint forces character-driven humor.
 4. **Assign each character a position on the awareness spectrum** — who knows what's really happening, who's oblivious, who's pretending?
 5. **Write dialogue by hand. Write the long version. Cut to the bone.** Preserve only texture lines that also reveal character.
 6. **Script pauses as micro-actions, not beats.** A character looking at their hands is a drawable moment; "beat" is not.
 7. **Execute the emotional turn mid-laugh** — never signal it, never prepare for it, never let the audience categorize the scene before it shifts.
 8. **Design the visual world to match the character's subjective experience, not objective reality.** Let the audience feel the gap.
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